

Less Known Facts About Venkata Simhadri

1. Venkata Simhadri got into the world of semiconductors by luck and coincidence. He is today helping shape the future of the semiconductor industry in India.
2. He quit PhD midway to move to Silicon Valley. Today, he employs individuals with PhD degrees at MosChip.
3. His wife is also a chip-design engineer. It was an arranged marriage, and Mrs Simhadri initially wanted to pursue software as a career.
4. He has completed his schooling from government schools that taught in Telugu medium.
5. He continues to discuss physics and maths with his dad, who used to teach in the same college Venkata completed his bachelor's from.
6. Venkata's family hails from a village called Bandalaicheruvu in Krishna district and, during his summer holidays, Venkata used to help his grandfather pick mangoes in their farm.

centre exactly located? In Silicon Valley! There's a lot that Venkata has accomplished being in Silicon Valley, apart from being able to play table tennis regularly.

Semiconductors was an accident

Credited for starting India's first chip physical design training facility, and a lot of other things in the chip industry, not many would believe that Venkata's venture into the industry was accidental!

"It was purely by accident. Those days there was very little private industry, and most of the recruitment was done either by the public sectors, or by the government. I was on a break after completing my graduation when my friend told me that his dad had something going in Delhi," he recalls.

At this point, the slow recruitment process of the public sector proved to be the biggest turning point of Venkata's life. Something that Venkata mentioned in the comment above was a venture that was promoted by the first Electronics Minister of India, Dr Sanjeevi Rao. This venture was focused on supplying quartzware for the semiconductor industry.

"That was the main turning point of my life," he recalls. "I never knew those conversations around physics with my father would help me become what I am today. When my friend's father gave me an opportunity to join the venture, I just grabbed it and moved to Delhi. Few months later, I was getting trained at India's first sem-

iconductor fab, Semiconductor Complex Limited (SCL) in Chandigarh. I was so fortunate, and it changed my life forever."

Just for info, Venkata topped physics exams throughout his academic innings. "I am thankful to my father, and thankful that he still talks to me about quantum physics, and other latest developments in the world of physics," he says.

Coming back to what Venkata has achieved in life, and the kind of academic innings he has had, he does not shy away from admitting that he was not at all a studious person. Instead, his focus was always on learning more about communications, English, playing with friends, and playing pranks on everyone he knew.

When asked if he would like to share a prank from his early days, he answered, "Those are the things that should not be discussed or shared," and he laughs with a child-like excitement in his eyes.

"I was branded as a trouble-maker in college, and I did get into trouble a lot of times for bunking classes. The level of the trouble amplified whenever my parents and teachers came to know that I had bunked classes to watch a movie," he shares laughingly. "I think my academic prowess mixed with sportsmanship and writing skills has helped me in my life more than anything else," he says.

Venkata's first job, as mentioned earlier, was with a startup that was supplying tools to SCL. Though, as Venkata recalls, the project didn't go well, he is thankful for being trained

in fab and getting exposed to the semiconductor industry. But that is not all, as a part of the startup, Venkata had a chance to visit the USA. "They sent me to LA to be a technical collaborator on the project. This was where I learned the process of making parts that we were supplying back in India. That was a breakthrough exposure for me," says Venkata.

PhD or Silicon Valley

As the project in Delhi didn't take-off as planned, Venkata went back to the USA for his Masters at New Jersey Institute of Technology. This was the point where Venkata switched his professional innings course more towards the design side. "I started working with Integrated Device Technology as a CAD Engineer. IDT was one of the top semiconductor companies in Silicon Valley back then. This is where my journey of designing semiconductors began," he shares.

IDT, recently, was acquired by The Renesas Group. Back in time, it was a semiconductor company that had its own fab, and packaging unit. It was a norm back then for semiconductor companies to have their own fab. It was only around the 1990s that the concept of being a fabless semiconductor company started and the model created semiconductor companies like Qualcomm and Broadcom.

"That time I used to work very closely with the fab. The reason I keep repeating about working in a fab is because when you work in a fab, you get exposure that isn't otherwise available for semiconductor professionals designing chips on a computer," he shares his experience.

As a matter of fact, most of the Indians working in a fabless design house today have never seen a fab, and there are strong chances that they might never see one in the future as well. Venkata explains that working in a fab opens a lot of dynamics around designing semiconductors and gives a different perspective and exposure. "I have been fortunate to work in a fab. For a semiconductor professional it is lucky to get a chance to work in a fab, and understand the process of ideation to production," he says.

Though Venkata has worked with